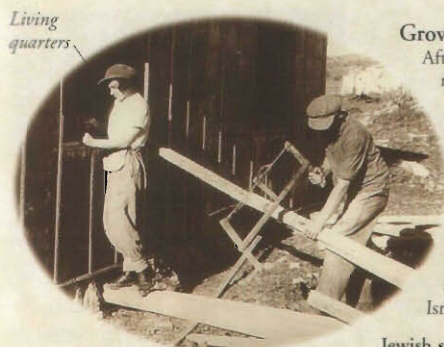




Growth of nationalism

After World War I, Asian nationalism (a belief in independence) grew. In 1918, Arab leaders overthrew Turkish rule. The desire of Jews to create an independent state in Palestine gained support. By 1933, 238,000 Jews had settled in Palestine, and, in 1948, the state of Israel was created.

Jewish settlers in Palestine, 1930s



World War II

In 1941–42, Japan occupied Burma, Indochina, and Indonesia. After the horrors of occupation, these areas rejected all foreign rule. In China, communist guerrillas resisting the Japanese, gained popular and political support.

Two war veterans on the Death Railway, River Kwai, Thailand, 1990s

Death Railway

During World War II, the Japanese built a railway to link Burma and Thailand to supply Japanese troops in Burma. Many thousands of Asian labourers and Western prisoners died from malnutrition, disease, and exhaustion building the 420-km (260-mile) railway, and it became known as the Death Railway.

Dragon economies

In the 1980s, Singapore, Taiwan, Hong Kong, and South Korea used their well-educated populations and high investment to become prosperous “dragon” economies. In the 1990s, Thailand, Malaysia, and Indonesia also developed rapidly.



Taiwanese factory

Taiwanese exported goods

Taiwan traditionally exported agricultural products, such as sugar, pineapples, and bananas; but by the 1980s it also exported advanced electronic products, such as personal computers, televisions, and portable phones.

Communist Asia

In 1949, the communists established the People's Republic of China – the world's largest communist state. In 1954, the North Vietnamese created an independent communist state. From the 1960s, communist movements in Indonesia and Malaysia threatened to overthrow existing governments.



US troops carrying wounded soldiers from a “chopper”



Khe Sanh, Vietnam

Middle East conflicts

Since 1948, Arab-Israeli territorial conflict, such as the war of 1973 (when Egypt and Syria attacked Israel), has dominated the Middle East. There have also been conflicts between Arab countries, such as the Iran-Iraq war (1980–88). Although the oil boom has helped this situation by lessening poverty, the situation in the Middle East remains unstable.

Oil rigs, Middle East

Vietnam War

From 1954, communist North Vietnam sought to reunite with non-communist South Vietnam by force. Originally a civil war, the Vietnam War escalated into an international conflict with the gradual intervention of the United States in the 1960s. Following defeats and heavy casualties, the USA agreed to withdraw in 1973. In 1975, northern forces unified both halves of Vietnam.

Timeline

c.618–907 The sophisticated T'ang dynasty dominates China.

1211 Mongol warrior Ghengis Khan invades China.

1300s Silk Road is shut.

1368 Ming dynasty expels Mongols from China.

1397 Mongols invade India.

1350–1460 Collapse of Khmer Empire, Cambodia.

1453 Fall of Constantinople to the Turkish Ottoman Empire.



Toy dog, Thailand, 1926

c.1488 Ming emperors rebuild the Great Wall of China.

1526–1707 Domination of Mughals in India.

1600–1614 British, French, and Dutch form East India companies.

1736–96 Manchu China prospers under Emperor Qianlong.

c.1750 Cultural and artistic peak in Japan.

1757 British take control of Bengal, India.

1839–42 First Opium War.



1907 Anglo-Russian agreement ends the Great Game in Central Asia.

1949 Chinese Revolution.

1950–53 Korean War.

1954–75 Vietnam War.

Toy robot, Japan, 1956

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